Ruthless!

By Joel Paley

Suggested Roles
ACTRESS 1: *Sylvia, Tina, Miss Thorn*
ACTRESS 2: *Judy, Louise, Announcer*

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

SYLVIA: **(Pg 9)** Good evening, my name is Sylvia St. Croix. Where does talent come from? Meet Judy Denmark. **(Pg 11)** A wife and mother leading an idyllic suburban life, and although Judy has absolutely no talent whatsoever, her only child, her daughter Tina has been blessed with a great deal of talent. Blessed, or dare I say, cursed? But I get ahead of myself.

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 2: *What do you get when you mix a struggling talent agent,*
ACTRESS 1: *A 1950's style stay-at-home mom,*
ACTRESS 2: *An elementary school teacher who has written her own (probably illegal) version of Pippi Longstocking*
ACTRESS 1: *And a 3rd grader who knows what she wants and will do* ***anything*** *to get it?*
ACTRESS 2: *You get a parody of the original Bad Seed! You get . . .*
TOGETHER: *Ruthless! by Joel Paley*

(Scene opens with Judy answering the telephone – Phone rings)

JUDY: **(Pg 12-13)** Tina's mother. . . Hello, Pastor Peters Tina has a choir solo Sunday? Oh, she just loves to sing and yes, she loves to pray. She's good at everything! She's positively heaven-sent. My kid's the perfect 8-year-old. Yes, she's enthralling. Thank you for calling. Good bye. *(She hangs up. Doorbell – Judy answers)* Won't you come in. *(Sylvia hands her a business card)* Miss St. Croix.

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SYLVIA: Please, call me Sylvia. **(Pg 14)** This lovely home, and of course the very reason I'm here . . . your daughter, Tina. I caught her performance last Saturday at The Rolling Hils Twilight Home for the Elderly. Sensational.

JUDY: We're very proud of our daughter. **(Pg 15)** Would you like to meet her? She's out in the garage breaking in her new tap shoes. *(calls off stage)* Tina! We have company. *(Tina enters)* Darling, say hello to Ms. St. Croix.

TINA: *(performs a jazzy dance combination)* Hi!

SYLVIA: *(claps enthusiastically)* **(Pg 16)** Tina, how would you like to be a star?

TINA: Why, it's all I've ever wanted! More than anything in the whole wide world!

SYLVIA: That's why I'm here. I work with specially gifted children. *(to Judy)* You are planning a theatrical career for your daughter, are you not?

JUDY: **(Pg 17)** We want our daughter to have a normal childhood.

TINA: I've had a normal childhood! It's time to move on. **(Pg 18)** Oh, Mama, please say yes. Please?!

JUDY: Well, I suppose some coaching can't hurt, but only after school.

SYLVIA: We start this afternoon!

TINA: *(shaking her head)* Today's the audition for the school show. I'm trying out for the lead.

SYLVIA: Oh, Judy, you must be so proud. I wish I had a little girl.

JUDY: Don't you have any children, Sylvia?

SYLVIA: Let's just say she didn't have any talent. **(Pg 19)** Oh, she used to jump around the living room. "Look, Mama, I'm dancing!" But she was merely jumping. It was embarrassing!

********* The Turner School Auditorium – Later that afternoon *********

MISS THORN: **(Pg 20)** Good afternoon, students. I'm Miss Thorn, and after directing last year's riveting production of Who's Afraid of Virginia Woolf, I'm delighted to announce this year, the Turner School will present "Pippi in Tahiti," the musical written and directed by me *(gesturing to herself)* Myra Thorn! **(Pg 21)** And now . . . the starring role of Pippi Lingstocking will be played by . . . Louise Lerman! *(Tina clearly is disappointed)*

********* The Denmark Living Room – later that afternoon *********

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SYLVIA: **(Pg 22)** You had your heart set on playing Pippi, didn't you?

TINA: It's the best part in the show! I don't understand.

JUDY: Oh, so what if Louise Lerman is playing Pippi -- You get to play Puddles!

TINA: *(Showing her true nature)* I don't want to play a dog. I mean, look at me. I was born to play Pippi Longstocking! *(She stomps her feet)* And Louise Lerman can't act!

JUDY: Now you listen to me, young lady, do you want to stay in showbusiness?

TINA: *(angelic)* You're right, Mother. What would you give me for a bucket of kisses? *[doorbell]* **(Pg 23)** I'll get it. *(Opening the door)* Why, good afternoon, Miss Thorn. Haven't changed your mind, have you?

MISS THORN: I'm afraid not. *(Tina pouts)*

JUDY: Miss Thorn, the reason I've asked you here is because Tina's awfully upset about not playing Pippi.

MISS THORN: I must admit, Mrs. Denmark, I've never known anyone to want a part so desperately.

SYLVIA: **(Pg 26)** My dear Miss Thorn, might you considered letting Tina be the Lerman girl's understudy?

MISS THORN: We're only giving one performance, but if it makes you happy then, yes, Tina can be Louise's understudy.

TINA: Wait a minute. You expect me to learn all of Pippi's songs and all of Pippi's lines -- and there's still a chance I don't even get to play Pippi?

MISS THORN: **(Pg 27)**That's correct.

SYLVIA: Unless, of course, something were to ***happen*** to Louise. *(she looks knowingly at Tina)*

TINA: *(Tina gets the message)* I'll do it!

******** The Turner School Auditorium – 6 weeks later *******

MISS THORN: **(Pg 32)** Okay, let's take it from after the storm at sea. Rachael Hobbs, stop giggling. This is a theater, not a playground. We're not here to have fun. Okay, here we go. Take your places for scene five. Go music!

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LOUISE: *(enters dressed as Pippi Longtocking; looks around in awe)* This must be Tahiti! And I'm Pippi! Pippi Longstocking! I'd like you to meet my best friend, Puddles! *(An unhappy Tina enters as the dog)* **(Pg 33)** Puddles and I were in a terrible storm. Our boat tipped over and everyone got drowned. But Puddles saved my life and brought me to this tropical paradise. Way to go, Puddles! Shake! *(holds out her hand)* You're supposed to shake my hand.

TINA: *(with an attitude)* Look! I don't think Puddles would want to shake hands here, ok? Not after being shipwrecked and having to doggy-paddle fifty miles!

LOUISE: I'm sorry, I can't act with this. *(gestures to Tina)*

TINA: You can't act period. The only reason you got the part is because Mommy and Daddy bought it for you.

LOUISE: **(Pg 34)** Do you honestly think I want to be in this stupid play? It's embarrassing. But it makes my parents happy, and when Mike and Betty are happy, I'm happy. Got it?

TINA: But I've ***got*** to play Pippi!

LOUISE: You don't have the range! *(Louise flippantly leaves the stage)*

TINA: *(menacingly)* I ASKED POLITELY. I SAID PLEASE . . . Now there's nothing left to do but . . . *(Sweetly)* Oh, Louise! *(exits after Louise)*

********** The Denmark Living Room – Later that afternoon*******

NEWSCASTER: **(Pg 35)** *(voice over)* Time for the local news. One of the students attending Turner Elementary School accidentally hung herself with a jump rope after falling from a catwalks high above the auditorium. The child's name is being withheld until parents can be notified. In other news . . .

JUDY: **(Pg 36)** That poor little girl.

TINA: *Tina enters from school)* Hello, Mother. We didn't have our lunch because something bad happened to Louise Lerman. *(smiling)* Can I have a hamburger?

JUDY: Of course. Now, sweetheart . . . if you want to go to your room . . . if you want to cry – or even stop smiling, I'll understand.

TINA: Why should I cry? I didn't get killed. *(Tina exits, then doorbell)*

MISS THORN: *(obviously shaken)* Hello, Mrs. Denmark.

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JUDY: **(Pg 37)** Come in, Miss Thorn. Of course, the play has been canceled.

MISS THORN: Whatever gave you that idea? I think this is an excellent opportunity for the children to learn that the show must go on!

JUDY: **(Pg 38)** But it's wrong. Shockingly wrong!

MISS THORN: **(Pg 37)** How's Tina. She **is** the understudy. *(losing it)* **(Pg 38)** Look, Mrs. D! That talented little girl of yours better be in costume and in place by show time, or I shall be forced to go to the police!

JUDY: The police?!

MISS THORN: It seems the Pippi wig is missing. Now, Tina ***was*** seen chasing Louise and snatching at the wig. But, I suspect nothing. Not a thing.

JUDY: Why don't you just come out and say it? Look me straight in the eye and tell me that my eight-year-old child killed for a part in the school play.

MISS THORN: Not just any part, Mrs. Denmark. The lead! *(she storms out)*

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JUDY: **(Pg 39)** *[Judy notices Tina's school bag by the door, she unzips it and pulls out the Pippi wig andwhispers in horror)* Tina!

TINA: Did you call me, Mother?

JUDY: What are you doing with Louise Lerman's Pippi wig? And don't lie.

TINA: *(with feigned innocence)* I found it after Louise had her. . . accident. I was afraid to give it to Miss Thorn. Afraid Miss Thorn would think I was naughty.

JUDY: Were you naughty, Tina?

TINA: *(innocently)* Oh, no, Mommy. I wasn't naughty. I found the wig and put it in my bag so it wouldn't get lost. **(Pg 40)** [Besides] It's my wig and it's my part! *(beat)* I love you and I think you're the best mother in the whole wide world. That's what I tell everyone.

JUDY: Knock it off, Tina. You're not that good! You did it, didn't you? You killed Louise Lerman for a part in a play?

TINA: Not just any part, Mother! The lead! I told Louise I had to play Pippi. But she said I didn't have the range. So, I chased her up onto the catwalk. That's when she gave me the wig. I

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asked her if that meant I could play Pippi and she said . . . "Yeah, over my dead body!" So I wrapped the jump rope around her fat neck and pushed her over the side.

JUDY: Oh, Tina, Tina!

TINA: I wanted the part. What could I do?

JUDY: You could have hurt her. You didn't have to kill her.

TINA: **(Pg 41)** I wasn't thinking. I was tired and I didn't have my lunch.

JUDY: Look at me, Tina. You did a bad thing, a very bad thing. You killed that little girl Do you know what that means?

TINA: *(beat and then with an evil smile)* Yeah, it means I'm playing Pippi!

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Joel Paley
ISBN: 978-0573704680
Publisher: Samuel French, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): July 2016
Revised in August 2015 to reflect the 2015 Off Broadway production.

AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier - MS
2017 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier
2020 National Qualifier
2023 National Qualifier
2024 National Qualifier
NIETOC
CO State Qualifier
IN State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
OH State Qualifier

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